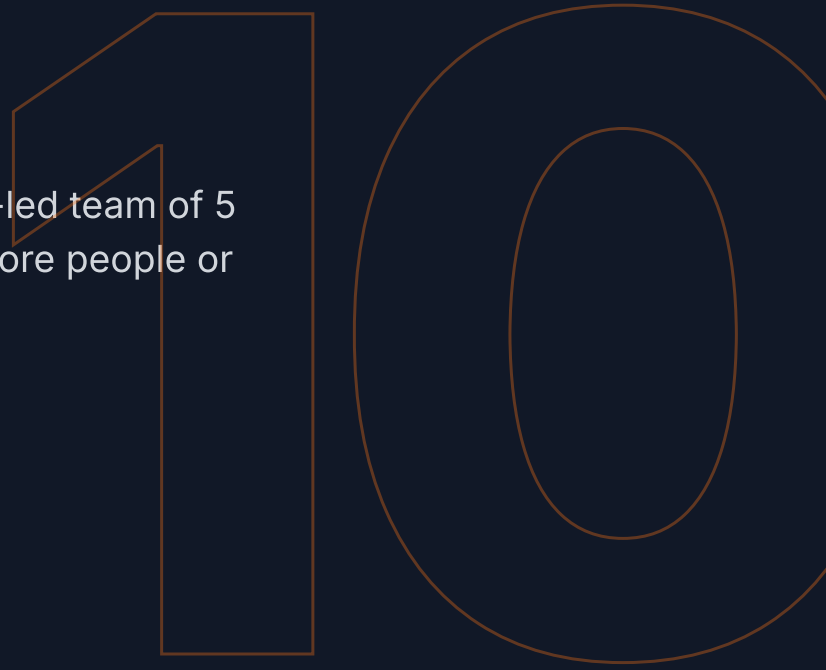


FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

Fix first, **scale** **smart**

The 10 operating systems a founder-led team of 5 to 20 people needs before adding more people or more AI.



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Why growth breaks things

At 3 people, a business runs on memory. Everyone hears every conversation, and the founder catches mistakes before a client sees them.

Somewhere between 5 and 20 people, that stops working. Work lands between two people and waits. New hires take months to get useful. The founder answers the same questions every day and becomes the bottleneck on every decision.

Hiring more people makes the noise louder, and AI added to a messy process produces the same mess faster.

The fix is a small set of operating systems: agreed ways of doing the recurring work, written down, owned by one person and reviewed. This guide covers the 10 that matter most for a founder-led team, in the order to build them.

How to use this guide

- Take the 10-question scorecard on the next page. It takes 5 minutes.
- Start with your lowest score. Each chapter covers one system: the signs, why it breaks, the fix, a template, an AI prompt and a first move for this week.
- Build one system at a time, and give each one 2 to 4 weeks alongside normal work.

Where does your team stand?

Score each statement: 0 for no, 1 for sort of, 2 for yes.

STATEMENT	0	1	2	
01 Every recurring function in the business has one named owner.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 1
02 We have a written list of our 5 to 8 core processes.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 2
03 Someone new could run our most common task from written instructions.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 3
04 Work moving from sales to delivery arrives with everything the next person needs.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 4
05 A new hire does useful work in their first week.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 5
06 When a deadline is going to slip, we know days before it does.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 6
07 We look at the same 5 to 15 numbers every week.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 7
08 Our meetings follow a fixed rhythm, and decisions get written down.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 8
09 When a problem repeats, we fix the cause and it stays fixed.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 9
10 The business could run for 2 weeks without the founder answering questions.	☐	☐	☐	Chapter 10

Your total out of 20 _____

16 to 20

Solid. Use the chapters for your 2 lowest scores.

10 to 15

Typical for a growing team. Start with your lowest score and work down.

Under 10

The founder is holding things together by hand. Start at chapter 1 and go in order.

01

SYSTEM 1 OF 10

Ownership: one name per function

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- "Who's handling this?" comes up every week.
- Two people each think the other one has it.
- Anything unclear lands on the founder's desk.
- Someone redoes work a colleague already finished.

WHY IT BREAKS

In a small team, everyone does a bit of everything. That works until a task has 2 half-owners, and then in practice it has none. Shared ownership feels collaborative and produces dropped balls.

THE FIX

1. List the functions the business runs on, before thinking about people. Most teams of 5 to 20 land on 6 to 10: sales, marketing, delivery, client service, finance, hiring, operations.
2. Put one name on each function. If two people share a box, decide who owns it and who helps.
3. Write down the 3 to 5 outcomes each owner answers for.
4. Circle the founder's name wherever it appears more than 3 times. Those are the first seats to hand over (chapter 10).

TEMPLATE: FUNCTION CARD

Function

Owner (one name)

Outcomes they answer for (3 to 5)

The number they watch weekly

Decisions they make without asking

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Draw the chart in 30 minutes. Share it with the team and ask what's wrong with it.

AI PROMPT

Here's a list of everyone on my team, their role, and what they spend their week on: [PASTE]. Group the work into 6 to 10 business functions, suggest one owner for each based on what they already do, and flag any function with no clear owner or more than one.

This is the Accountability Chart from EOS (Gino Wickman, Traction). Its main rule is one seat, one name.

02

SYSTEM 2 OF 10

Core processes: name your 5 to 8

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- The same job gets done 3 different ways depending on who does it.
- Quality depends on who's working that day.
- Nobody can explain how a client gets from signed to delivered.

WHY IT BREAKS

Most small businesses run on 5 to 8 processes that produce most of the revenue and most of the problems. Until they're named and mapped, nobody can improve them, train people on them or automate them.

THE FIX

1. List the processes that repeat every week or month: winning a client, onboarding a client, delivering the work, invoicing and collecting, hiring.
2. Map how the most painful one runs today with the people who do it: each step, who does it, which tool, and where it waits. Sticky notes or a whiteboard photo is enough.
3. Mark every place work waits, gets redone or needs the founder.
4. Agree on one simpler way to run it, and give it an owner from chapter 1.

TEMPLATE: PROCESS MAP, ONE LINE PER STEP

Step

Who does it

Tool used

What they need before starting

What they hand on

Typical wait before the next step

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Pick the process clients or staff complain about most. Map it this week with the people who do it.

AI PROMPT

Here are notes from a team conversation about how we handle [PROCESS] today: [PASTE NOTES or TRANSCRIPT]. Turn them into a step-by-step map showing who does each step, what tool they use and where work waits. Then list the 3 changes that would remove the most waiting or rework. Ask me questions if anything is unclear.

03 Documentation: get knowledge out of heads

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- "Ask Sarah, she knows how."
- One person's vacation slows the whole team down.
- The same questions show up in chat every week.

WHY IT BREAKS

Knowledge that lives in one person's head turns them into a bottleneck and leaves when they do. It also blocks AI. An AI tool can follow a process only after someone has written it down.

THE FIX

1. Start with the core processes from chapter 2, most painful first.
2. Record the person who does it best walking through it on screen, with Loom or a similar tool. 10 minutes is plenty.
3. Turn the recording into a one-page SOP (standard operating procedure) with the headings below.
4. Keep every SOP in one shared place, with an owner and a review date. Update it whenever a problem shows it's wrong.

TEMPLATE: ONE-PAGE SOP

Name and owner

Last reviewed

When to use it

Steps, numbered

What done looks like

Common mistakes

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Record one process this week. Have someone else follow the SOP cold, and fix whatever confused them.

AI PROMPT

Here's the transcript of a screen recording where [NAME] walks through how we [TASK]: [PASTE]. Write a one-page SOP with these headings: when to use it, numbered steps, what done looks like, common mistakes. Keep the steps short and use our terms. List anything the transcript skipped that a new person would need.

04 Handoffs: stop losing work between people

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- Delivery learns what the client wants on the kickoff call.
- Work sits in someone's inbox for days before anyone notices.
- Clients repeat themselves to 3 different people.

WHY IT BREAKS

Every time work changes hands, context can drop. In most service businesses the costliest handoff is sales to delivery, where promises made in the sale never reach the people doing the work.

THE FIX

1. List every handoff in your core processes, and cut any that aren't needed.
2. For each one left, define "ready": the information the next person needs before they accept the work.
3. Turn that into a short form the sender fills in. The receiver can send it back if something's missing.
4. Put all active work on one shared board (Trello, Asana, ClickUp or a spreadsheet) so waiting work is visible to everyone.

TEMPLATE: SALES-TO-DELIVERY HANDOFF

Client and decision maker

What we promised, in their words

Scope and exclusions

Deadline and why it matters to them

Budget

Known risks

Files and links

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Ask your delivery team what they wished they'd known on day one of the last 3 projects. That list is your handoff form.

AI PROMPT

Here are the notes or transcript from our final sales call with [CLIENT]: [PASTE]. Fill in our handoff form: what we promised, scope, exclusions, deadline, budget, decision maker and risks. Quote the client's own words for anything they stressed, and mark anything missing with [ASK].

05

SYSTEM 5 OF 10

Onboarding: useful in week one

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- New hires spend their first days waiting for logins.
- It takes months before someone is fully useful.

WHY IT BREAKS

In a small team a slow start is expensive, because one new hire can be 10% of your headcount. Without a plan, onboarding becomes shadowing whoever has time, and new people learn the workarounds along with the work.

THE FIX

1. Write a first-30-days plan for each role: what they'll learn, do and own by day 5, 15 and 30.
2. Make a pre-start checklist: accounts, equipment, documents and a first-week calendar.
3. Point them to the SOPs from chapter 3 and give them one real task in week 1.
4. Assign a buddy and hold short check-ins at days 7, 30 and 90. Ask what was confusing and fix the plan.

TEMPLATE: 30-DAY PLAN

Before day 1: accounts, kit, documents

Week 1: one real task

Owns by day 15

Owns by day 30

Who to ask for what

Check-in dates

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Ask your newest hire what they wish they'd had in week 1. Write it down before they forget.

AI PROMPT

I'm hiring a [ROLE] for my [TYPE OF BUSINESS] of [N] people. Here are our SOPs and tools: [LIST]. Draft a 30-day onboarding plan with a pre-start checklist, a real task for week 1, and what they should own by day 15 and day 30. Keep it realistic for a small team with no HR department.

06

SYSTEM 6 OF 10

Workload: finish more by starting less

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- Everything is "almost done".
- Deadlines slip by a few days, every time.
- People are busy all day and little gets shipped.

WHY IT BREAKS

Most missed deadlines come from too much work started at once. Every extra task in progress means more switching between tasks and less finishing. Estimates based on how long things should take, with no record of how long they did take, make it worse.

THE FIX

1. Put every active piece of work on the shared board from chapter 4, including the small stuff.
2. Limit how many items each person has in progress, usually 2 or 3. Finish before starting something new.
3. Record start and finish dates for a month, and use the real numbers for future estimates.
4. Leave room for surprises. If a fifth of each week goes to unplanned work, plan only the other four fifths.

TEMPLATE: WEEKLY WORKLOAD CHECK

Person

Items in progress

Oldest open item, in days

Blocked items, and by whom

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Count what each person has in progress today. Anyone above 3 finishes something before starting anything new.

AI PROMPT

Here's an export of our project board with start dates, due dates, owners and status: [PASTE]. Show me who has the most work in progress, which items have been open longest, and where work is waiting on someone else. Suggest which 3 items to finish or pause first.

Dominica DeGrandis covers this well in Making Work Visible, and Eliyahu Goldratt's The Goal explains why the slowest step sets the pace.

07 Scorecard: the numbers you check every week

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- You find out about problems at month end.
- Meetings argue opinions because nobody has the numbers.

WHY IT BREAKS

Monthly financials tell you what already happened. A handful of weekly numbers shows trouble while there's still time to act on it.

THE FIX

1. Pick 5 to 15 numbers that predict how next month will go: leads, sales calls booked, proposals sent, projects on schedule, invoices overdue, cash in the bank.
2. Give each number an owner from chapter 1 and a weekly target.
3. Put them in one spreadsheet: one row per number, one column per week.
4. Review it in the same weekly meeting (chapter 8). Anything off target goes on the issues list (chapter 9).

TEMPLATE: WEEKLY SCORECARD

Number

Owner

Weekly target

This week

Last 13 weeks

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Write down the 5 numbers you'd want to see after a month away. Start tracking them on Monday.

AI PROMPT

I run a [TYPE OF BUSINESS] with [N] people. Our revenue comes from [HOW]. Suggest 10 weekly numbers that would warn me about problems in sales, delivery and cash at least a month ahead. For each, say who on a small team should own it and how to collect it with [TOOLS WE USE].

EOS calls this a Scorecard. The format matters less than looking at it every single week.

08 Meeting rhythm: decide once, write it down

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- Meetings run long and decide nothing.
- Decisions made in chat get lost.
- People find out about changes by accident.
- The same topic comes up in 3 meetings in a row.

WHY IT BREAKS

At 5 people, communication happens by overhearing. At 15, it has to be designed, or information travels only through the founder.

THE FIX

1. Set a fixed rhythm: a 15-minute check-in daily or twice a week, a 60 to 90 minute weekly team meeting, and a half-day planning session each quarter.
2. Use the same agenda for the weekly meeting every time (below).
3. Write down decisions, owners and deadlines in one place during the meeting.
4. Agree on channels: chat for quick questions, the project board for task status, the shared docs hub for anything that should last.

TEMPLATE: WEEKLY MEETING AGENDA

Scorecard review, 5 minutes

Priorities on or off track, 5 minutes

Customer and team news, 5 minutes

Issues: solve the top 3, most of the time

Recap decisions and owners, 5 minutes

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Run next week's team meeting on the fixed agenda, and give it 4 weeks before judging it.

AI PROMPT

Here's the transcript of our weekly team meeting: [PASTE]. List every decision made, every task with its owner and deadline, and every issue raised but not resolved. Format it so I can paste it into [TOOL]. Flag anything where the owner or deadline wasn't clear.

09

SYSTEM 9 OF 10

Issues: fix the cause and stop firefighting

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- The same problems come back every month.
- Urgent work crowds out planned work most weeks.
- Fixes are workarounds that nobody writes down.

WHY IT BREAKS

Firefighting feels productive, and it keeps a business stuck. Each workaround saves an hour today and costs another hour next week.

THE FIX

1. Keep one visible issues list that anyone on the team can add to.
2. In the weekly meeting, take the top 3 one at a time: find the cause, decide the fix, name an owner.
3. Keep asking "why" until you reach something you can change in a process. Five rounds is usually enough.
4. When a fix changes how work gets done, update the SOP so it stays fixed.

TEMPLATE: ISSUE LOG

Issue

Date raised

Cause

Fix

Owner

SOP updated? Yes or no

YOUR FIRST MOVE

List the last 10 fires your team put out. Circle every one that happened more than once.

AI PROMPT

Here is our issues log for the last 3 months: [PASTE]. Group the issues by likely root cause, show which causes come up most often, and suggest a process fix for the top 3. Tell me which SOP each fix would change.

EOS calls this IDS: identify, discuss, solve.

10 The founder bottleneck: hand over decisions

SIGNS YOU NEED THIS

- Most decisions wait for you.
- Your inbox is the team's to-do list.
- A week off means work stops.

WHY IT BREAKS

Founders hold on because they're faster and it's their name on the work. Past about 5 people, every decision routed through one person sets the speed limit for the whole business.

THE FIX

1. For 2 weeks, log every question and decision that comes to you.
2. Sort them into 3 groups: decisions only you should make, decisions someone else could make with a rule, and questions an SOP should answer.
3. Write the rules down, for example "Refunds under \$500: the client service owner decides."
4. Hand one function from chapter 1 to its new owner each quarter, with its SOPs, its numbers and its decision rules.

TEMPLATE: DECISION RIGHTS

Decision

Who decides

Limit (money, time or risk)

Who must be told afterwards

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Start the log today, in a note on your phone.

AI PROMPT

Here's a 2-week log of every question and decision that came to me: [PASTE]. Sort them into 3 groups: only I should decide, someone else could decide with a clear rule, and an SOP should answer this. For the second group, draft the rule and suggest who should own it.

WHERE AI FITS

Systems first. Then AI makes them faster.

Every chapter ends with an AI prompt, and every prompt works better once the system underneath it exists. AI can draft an SOP from a screen recording or fill in a handoff form from a sales call.

It can't decide who owns what or which processes matter most. Those calls are yours, and they come first.

Start with the workflow. Then the tool.

Not sure which system to fix first? A Forersight AI Readiness Audit maps your workflows, scores these 10 systems, and ranks where AI will save your team the most time.

Book an AI Readiness Audit at davidjforer.com

Further reading: Gino Wickman, Traction (Accountability Chart, Scorecard and IDS). Dominica DeGrandis, Making Work Visible. Eliyahu M. Goldratt, The Goal.



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